forum was used to voice rhetoric against the West, something which New Delhi would have preferred to avoid. Most importantly, the SCO was a group of countries comprising communists, autocrats, and semi-democrats, with policies on human rights, ethnic groups, and religion at odds with India's basic principles. Finally, sceptics at home would criticise India for joining a Chinese-led body as a junior member.

Nevertheless, despite all its demerits, India recognised the SCO as one of the remarkable regional forums in the Eurasian space in the post–Cold War era. The high-profile SCO summits since the organisation took form as SCO in 2001 drew huge global media attention, and its declarations had profound and growing diplomatic impact, both in the region and beyond. At the 5th SCO Summit in Astana in 2005, India received status as observer and expressed its intention to be a part of the SCO.[5] Since then India has been enthusiastically participating in all SCO activities as an observer, even as many commentators have continued to convey the view that a high-profile country like India needs to chart its own course and not seek membership in an organisation where it will have a lesser political voice and status. In the following, I will outline the main reasons for India joining the SCO.

India's stakes

First, with high stakes for India in the Eurasian security and economic spheres, staying outside of the SCO cannot be to India's advantage, and New Delhi sees potential gains from being a full member of the SCO. India has thus taken a broader view and decided to seriously engage with the Eurasian region under the auspices of the SCO, particularly with the motive of enhancing common political stability and